

Embassy and airport

A similar situation was unfolding at the US Embassy in downtown Saigon. Armed with mortars, grenades, automatic weapons, and explosive charges, the Viet Cong blasted their way through the front gate and into the landscaped area surrounding the six-story structure. As American diplomats sought safety inside, a firefight ensued between the Viet Cong and the Marines and military police guarding the diplomatic enclave. US troops managed to prevent the attackers from storming the building, but could not immediately drive them from the compound outside. Reinforcements were on their way to the embassy but had no idea of the obstacles they might face along the way.

The situation was far less desperate at Tan Son Nhut airbase on the outskirts of Saigon, where the Seventh Air Force Command had raised its security alert to the highest level just before Tet. Although Viet Cong sappers breached the perimeter and hundreds of attackers flooded into the airbase, USAF reaction forces were able to respond quickly and beat back the attack with relatively little loss of life or damage to Air Force aircraft and structures.

By daybreak, Saigon was shrouded in smoke from fires sparked by the overnight fighting, and the smell of cordite and the sound of gunfire drifted across the capital. Entire sections of Saigon were under Viet Cong control, including the Cholon district, where many of the city's ethnic Chinese resided. The streets were strewn with the bodies of combatants from both sides and hundreds of civilians caught in the crossfire. Civilians who survived the carnage huddled in their shops or houses, tending to wounded family and friends.



Spoils of war

Captured Viet Cong guerrillas are displayed alongside Soviet arms seized during fighting to retake Saigon's Cholon district. Among the weapons are automatic rifles, rockets, Sten guns, and ammunition clips.